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A Santa Rosa church with anti-LGBTQ+ stance got $400,000 from California to improve security

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Author: PHIL BARBER; THE PRESS DEMOCRAT| Section: News| 1632 Words
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Jason Newman was reading his local newspaper in late June when he came across a story on local churches, synagogues and religious schools set to receive funding under the California State Nonprofit Security Grant Program, which helps places of worship better defend themselves against violent attacks and hate crimes.

When Newman, a Petaluma-based marriage and family therapist, glanced at the list of award winners, he immediately felt his anger rise. Receiving a pair of $200,000 grants from the Governor's Office of Emergency Services is Victory Outreach Santa Rosa, a church near the western terminus of Sebastopol Road.

A week and a half earlier, Newman, who is gay, had rallied outside the downtown Santa Rosa branch of the Sonoma County Library to show support for the library system's "drag story hours." Most of the anti-drag protesters at the library that afternoon were from Victory Outreach, he said.

"At one point, one of them called me a "f****t," Newman said, repeating a common gay slur. "One even pushed a woman. I didn't get that on video, unfortunately. But what I do have, he was screaming in someone's face afterward They were definitely getting aggressive."

Now that same church is being handed $400,000 to help it accomplish its mission with a greater sense of security.

"The little it says in the (state) contract, it's supposed to be protecting against hate crimes," Newman said. "But you can't be an agitator and a victim at the same time. (Victory Outreach is) playing the role of both sides. They're agitating people on purpose to make them fearful, and trying to stop them from normalizing behavior that should be normalized."

Also on the list of grant recipients is Calvary Chapel The Rock, a Santa Rosa church that also has been accused of anti-LGBTQ+ sentiments. In 2022, The Press Democrat profiled Wylder Reinman, who said he was ostracized by the church and by his family after coming out as gay as a teenager. His father, Ross Reinman, is the pastor at The Rock. Several former church members backed Wylder Reinman's account.

Victory Outreach Santa Rosa pastor Jose Guadarrama rejected the anti-LGBTQ+ label and, like many of the people protesting the drag story hour, framed the issue as a matter of safeguarding children.

"I think the kids are small to be exposed," Guadarrama told The Press Democrat. "Some of the conversations that are brought forth there, they may be sexual conversations, change of sex, all those things. We're trying to make a stand, that we should wait until they grow a little more and gain some understanding of things. To say we hate gays, that's a complete lie."

Guadarrama argued that Victory Outreach Santa Rosa includes families with gay children and "transgenders who have come to our church." He loves them, but will not flinch from delivering the message of the Bible to them.

"It's not how I feel about them, or what the world feels about them," Guadarrama said. "What does the Bible say? That's what we stand on. But we do it with love."

Church condemns homosexuality

The official stance of Victory Outreach International, the Santa Rosa church's umbrella organization, is anything but gay-positive, though.

"Victory Outreach does not endorse homosexuality or lesbianism; we consider both to be immoral and contrary to biblical teaching," the international body states on its website, in a long document describing its beliefs.

The "Beliefs" document condemns violence against gays, but makes it clear that without renouncing their sexual preference, queer people can't be full members of the church.

"In their misguided liberalism, certain Christian groups now claim that it is possible to be both gay and Christian," Victory Outreach International states. "Clearly, this humanistic rationalization contradicts fundamental Scripture and constitutes a grave delusion that could have eternal consequences."

Some individual Victory Outreach locations — there are more than 100 across California — include the international organization's "Beliefs" on their own websites. Victory Outreach Santa Rosa does not.

However, Guadarrama made his views clear on Father's Day, when he urged followers to show up at the downtown Santa Rosa library at 2 p.m. to protest the arrival of Drag King Vera to read books to children.

"There is a group of people that are coming in and teaching our little ones some weird, demonic, evil stuff," Guadarrama cautioned during his sermon that day, a video of which is posted on the church's website. "I said it. It's demonic. And they're zeroing in, they're focusing on the little ones. Why are they doing that to the little ones? Because … there is a spirit behind all this, that wants to destroy this generation."

The pastor reminded his worshippers again just before the service ended. He urged them not to "get crazy" at the library. He also suggested those protesting the drag story hours not disclose their association with the church.

"We're not gonna go like, 'Hey, this is Victory Outreach!'" Guadarrama said. "No, no, no. We go there as concerned citizens in this community."

But some Victory Outreach members did identify themselves later that afternoon. One told The Press Democrat at the time that he was there to support the church. During the interview, a church official walked over and said she didn't want Victory Outreach's name included.

Response to armed standoff

The California State Nonprofit Security Grant Program was created in 2019, and extended last September by Gov. Gavin Newsom via Assembly Bill 1664. That bill was introduced by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, a Democrat who represents the heart of the San Fernando Valley in Southern California. It was his response to the armed standoff at Congregation Beth Israel in Colleyville, Texas, in January 2022.

"In a world where hate crimes and antisemitism are on the rise, we need more than thoughts and prayers to keep us safe," Gabriel said when AB 1664 passed the California legislature. "This new law will provide critical resources to protect vulnerable communities and sends a powerful message that California stands firmly with those targeted by hate."

The grant program offers a total of $47.5 million, doled out in $200,000 awards, to houses of worship seeking to harden defenses through reinforced doors and gates, alarm systems, security guards and other measures. Each grantee can receive up to $500,000.

Victory Outreach Santa Rosa was awarded two grants, one for its church building and another for an outdoor event center. (No other Victory Outreach International locations in California are receiving money.) The event center, according to Guadarrama, is a tented space Victory Outreach employs for children's activities like a recent pinewood derby.

The church will use the money to purchase and install "nice, secure fencing," Guadarrama said.

No justification

To Jason Newman, the Petaluma therapist, there's no justification for the state helping to finance that project.

"Absolutely not. Not when there's a hate group involved," Newman said.

The Governor's Office of Emergency Services is limited by the guidelines of AB 1664 in evaluating the worthiness of grant recipients, according to Brian Ferguson, the agency's deputy director for crisis communication & public affairs.

Ferguson declined an interview request, but outlined the grant criteria in an email. Applicants must be nonprofit organizations under Section 501(c) (3) of the Internal Revenue Code. And they must identify and substantiate specific threats of attack, potential consequences and the susceptibility of their physical infrastructure.

"The State of California is strongly committed to preventing discrimination or harassment based on sexual orientation, gender identity and other protected characteristics like race, religion and ethnicity," Ferguson wrote. "All grant subrecipients must comply with state and federal Equal Employment Opportunity and Civil Rights laws. Failure to comply with these requirements may result in the possible discontinuance of grant funding."

The condemnation of homosexuality may be seen as hateful by many Sonoma County residents, but it's unlikely to violate such laws.

Marc Levine, who co-sponsored AB 1664 as an Assembly member representing the North Bay, stood behind the intent of the bill.

"This is an important grant program," said Levine, whose district included part of Sonoma County and all of Marin. "I'm glad this money is flowing to Sonoma County nonprofits to protect citizens in their houses of worship. I can't speak to specific grant applications, because I haven't seen them since leaving office."

Levine opted not to run for reelection last year in favor of an unsuccessful bid for Insurance Commissioner. He is currently running for a seat on the Marin County Board of Supervisors.

Victory Outreach International, which grew from humble beginnings in 1967, now represents a sprawling network of churches — well over 100 in California alone, and many more in 23 other states and nations as far flung as Indonesia, Scotland and Ecuador.

It recruits heavily from inner-city communities. Much of its work is in lifting people out of poverty, drug dependency and gang affiliation. The Santa Rosa church is heavily Latino, and that would seem to be true of many other Victory Outreach locations in the U.S.

Guadarrama has been involved with Victory Outreach for 34 years, he said. He grew up in Oakland, raised by a single mother, and at a very young age got connected with "kids involved in alcohol, cutting school and gang activity."

"At the worst time in my life, Victory Outreach stepped in," Guadarrama said. "They taught me from the Bible. A lot of people in the church are that way. They used to be terrible people, now their lives are an example. I've been all over the world. I just got back from Capetown, South Africa. So my life has changed. This is what I try to teach people: You can change."

Victory Outreach's messaging makes that offer to gay people, too — a chance to change, based on the church's version of Biblical doctrine. Jason Newman isn't interested.

"When I was 14 years old, I tried to kill myself. I thought there was something wrong with me," Newman said. "Now I know there's not, and thank god."

Press Democrat reporter Madison Smalstig contributed to this story. You can reach Phil Barber at 707-521-5263 or phil.barber@pressdemocrat.com. On Twitter @Skinny_Post.

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